THIS WEEK'S FILE · FOUNDER FILE #008

PIETER LEVELS AND THE 40,870-LINE FILE THAT EARNS $80,000 A MONTH

A self-taught Dutch developer runs a portfolio of AI and non-AI products alone, on plain PHP, with no investors and no employees. His own figures are public, they move around a lot, and here is what they actually say.

THE FILE

FOUNDER	Pieter Levels, Solo founder
COMPANY	Photo AI, Interior AI, Nomad List and Remote OK
FOUNDED	Undisclosed (a portfolio of 40+ products)
HQ	Nomadic
SECTOR	AI image products and online communities
STAGE	Bootstrapped, solo
FUNDING	None (never raised venture capital)
MODEL	Subscriptions and credits across a portfolio of products

Hello again, and welcome to File #008. Thank you for staying with us.

Somewhere on a server there is a single file called index.php. In March 2026 it was 40,870 lines long. According to the man who wrote it, that one file runs a business called Photo AI that made $105,000 in revenue and $80,000 in profit in a month.

It is a delightful, slightly alarming fact, and it is the reason this file is about Pieter Levels. He is one of the most famous solo founders in the world, he publishes his numbers constantly, and the way he builds is the opposite of what most people would advise. This week we look at what he does, what the numbers do and don't show, and what is worth copying. (All figures are in US dollars. All are his own.)

THE SHORT VERSION

- **Who:** Pieter Levels, a self-taught Dutch developer, known online as @levelsio, who has been building in public for more than a decade.

- **What:** a portfolio of products he runs alone. Photo AI makes realistic photos of you from a few selfies. Interior AI redesigns a room from a photo. Nomad List and Remote OK, which are not AI products, are older sites that still earn.
- **Why it matters:** it is a working example of a one-person company built on a deliberately simple stack, with AI as both the product and the way he builds some of it.
- **The number to remember:** 40,870. The lines of code in the single file behind Photo AI, in March 2026. It was almost 14,000 lines in July 2023, when he said it was making $61,808 a month.

THE FOUNDER

Pieter Levels says he has launched at least 70 projects, though in 2024 the Lex Fridman podcast described him as having launched “over 40 startups”. Either way, he says most ideas don’t work. He sold $50,000 of preorders for his book about making products before he had written it, which he puts down to a decade of posting in public: about 125,000 tweets by his count.

He is solo by choice. He says he doesn’t enjoy managing people and prefers creating, and that automation is what lets a single person run many projects. He has never raised venture capital and says he would rather own a $10 million a year company outright than risk a go-big-or-bust path. He has worked from a laptop while travelling for about a decade, living in more than 40 countries.

THE STACK

His stack is the first surprise. On the Lex Fridman podcast he described it as “vanilla HTML, jQuery, PHP and SQLite”. He says he still uses jQuery, that PHP “just stays the same and works”, and that frameworks take a lot of work to maintain. He calls his scepticism of framework fashion his most controversial take, and says his choice was partly accidental because he never found time to learn Node.

The extreme version is Photo AI. By his own post, the whole site is one PHP file, and reports say it runs on a single dedicated server. Whether that is a stroke of genius or a risk is for you to judge, but for him it has a practical benefit: one person can hold the whole thing in his head.

THE PRODUCTS AND THE NUMBERS

Every figure is his. None has been audited.

WHEN	PRODUCT	WHAT HE SAID
2024 (Lex Fridman)	Interior AI	Went from about $10,000 a month to “forty, fifty” thousand, about two years in

WHEN	PRODUCT	WHAT HE SAID
2024 (Lex Fridman)	An earlier avatar app	About $150,000 in a week, and “ten k a day” at the peak. Photo AI was a pivot from it
July 2023	Photo AI	Almost 14,000 lines of raw PHP, making $61,808 a month
September 2024	Photo AI	A record month of about $161,000, with GPU costs flagged as a major expense
July 2025	Whole portfolio	About $3.1 million a year, solo (stated by John Collison on Stripe’s podcast)
March 2026	Photo AI	$105,000 revenue and $80,000 profit in a month
Late September 2026	Photo AI	Listed at about $86,000 a month on a tracker that cites him
September 2026	Whole portfolio	Combined revenue and investment gains past $10 million a year, with business revenue “stable” at $200,000 to $250,000 a month (as reported by a data service; we couldn’t read the original post)

Three things to notice.

The numbers move. Photo AI has ranged from $161,000 in a record month in 2024 to $105,000 in early 2026 to roughly $86,000 later in 2026, if you take the tracker’s figure. That is not a collapse, and it is not a straight line either. Always date the number.

The margin is high, and unexplained. $80,000 on $105,000 is about 76 percent. He doesn’t itemise the costs, so the $25,000 gap is our arithmetic, not his statement.

Some secondary figures don’t add up. A summary of his Stripe podcast lists Remote OK at $3.4 million, Nomad List at $700,000 and Photo AI at $600,000, which together exceed the $3.1 million he is said to earn in total. We have left those out. Two other claims that circulate, a $150,000 Photo AI month in September 2025 and a suggestion that he is open to selling Photo AI and Interior AI, we could not find anywhere, so we have not used them. In the July 2025 interview he said he had not sold his projects.

HOW AI SHOWS UP IN HIS WORK

There are three different ways, and they are worth separating.

AI as the product. Photo AI and Interior AI are built on image models. The Photo AI business is, in effect, a fast, well-packaged use of other people’s models, trained on each customer’s selfies.

AI as a collaborator in building. In February 2025 he built a free multiplayer flight simulator game, fly.pieter.com, using Cursor, the AI coding tool, in about three hours. Reports of what it earned vary widely, from $87,000 in a month to a figure over $1 million a year, and we would treat all of them as unverified. In 2025 he also ran a game-jam contest for AI-built games. In August 2026 he posted that he had “vibecoded” a full video editor into

Photo AI. He is also an investor in Cursor.

AI as an operator. He uses the GPT API to moderate a community of about 40,000 people. It mutes users for set periods instead of banning them, which he says is more neutral than his own moderation. He also says traffic from ChatGPT referrals rose from about 4 percent to about 20 percent of his total in a month.

THE OPERATING RHYTHM

From his own interviews, the rhythm is simple.

1. **Launch small and fast,** and treat most ideas as experiments.
2. **Watch whether people pay.** He advises validating first and aiming for real traction, such as $50,000 to $100,000 a month, before scaling.
3. **Start payments with a hosted payment link,** not a full integration.
4. **Keep what works, and keep the old things running.** One of his oldest products still earns about $50 a month with its code essentially unchanged for around ten years.
5. **Put the profits somewhere safe.** He advises low-cost index funds, not spending everything.
6. **Use the audience.** Nearly everything he launches is announced to a very large following.

> **Try this**
>
> **Ask what could live in one file.** Before reaching for a framework, ask whether your product could run as something one person can read in an afternoon. Pieter's argument is that simplicity is how a single person stays in control.
>
> **Start with a payment link.** If you can sell it with a hosted checkout page, don't build a payments system yet.
>
> **Use AI to remove a repetitive chore.** Pieter's community moderation is a small, well-defined task that a model does consistently. List yours.
>
> **Keep a build-in-public log.** The number he publishes is also his marketing. If you can't share a figure, share a decision.

WHAT COULD GO WRONG

Self-reported, and moving. All of it comes from his posts and interviews, not an audit. His own record shows that revenue goes up and down.

Dependence on other people's models. Photo AI and Interior AI rely on third-party image models and rented computing power. A better or cheaper model from a bigger company can erode the advantage overnight, and GPU costs are a real expense.

The architecture. One enormous file and a very small stack is a defensible choice for a skilled solo developer. It's harder to hand over, secure or scale, and a reader who isn't Pieter

shouldn't assume it transfers.

Key-person risk. There is no second person. His health, attention or appetite are the business's. The portfolio of old projects softens that, but not entirely.

Audience dependence. His distribution is his following on X. He is an outspoken user of the platform, including on politics, and that is part of the picture, though not the subject of this file.

WHAT TO WATCH

1. **Whether Photo AI's monthly revenue stabilises,** and what the next dated figure says.
2. **The video editor.** Does the AI video feature he added in August 2026 become a new revenue line or stay a feature?
3. **Competition from the big model makers,** whose own image and video tools keep improving.
4. **What he does with his own advice about selling.** We found no sale announcement. Any move to sell the AI products would change the story.

One file, one man, and a big audience. The unusual part isn't the AI. It's the discipline to keep things small enough to hold in your head.

That's File #008. Thank you for reading it. If it made you think of someone, forward it along, and if there's a founder you'd like to see opened next, tell us at info@aifounderfiles.com. File #009 lands next Sunday.

Where this came from: Pieter Levels' own posts and interviews, with figures as he reports them. Third-party trackers are labelled as such. Nothing has been verified independently. Claude, made by Anthropic, helped research and draft this file. Spotted a mistake? Email info@aifounderfiles.com and we'll correct it.

SOURCES

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